

Executive Summary

Does National Individualism Predict AI Sentiment?

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July 2026

Question. Global surveys consistently show that countries like Indonesia (85%) and Thailand (78%) see AI as overwhelmingly beneficial, while countries like Canada (40%) and the United States (42%) are far more skeptical. This analysis tests one of the leading explanations from cross-cultural psychology: does a country's position on Hofstede's Individualism Index statistically predict its AI sentiment?

Method. Hofstede's Individualism Index (IDV) was correlated against Ipsos's 2025 AI Monitor survey (30 countries, n=23,216 adults), specifically the item "AI has more benefits than drawbacks."

Test	Result
Pearson correlation	$r = -0.85, p = 2.8 \times 10^{-9}$
Linear model	$R^2 = 0.72$
Robustness check (24 verified-source countries)	$r = -0.83, p = 5.2 \times 10^{-7}$

Key findings.

- **Individualism explains roughly 72% of the cross-country variation in AI sentiment** – a strong, statistically robust relationship. More individualistic countries are significantly less optimistic about AI; more collectivist countries are significantly more optimistic.
- **The result survives a data-quality robustness check.** Six of the 30 countries' IDV scores came from a less-certain supplementary source rather than a single consistent table. Excluding these six barely changes the result ($r = -0.83$ vs. -0.85), increasing confidence the finding isn't an artifact of that data-quality gap.
- **China is not in this analysis.** The frequently cited "China 83%" AI optimism figure comes from a different Ipsos survey wave than the 30-country sample used here – worth knowing before assuming this dataset covers every country commonly discussed in AI sentiment coverage.

Honest caveat. This is a correlational, bivariate finding. It does not control for other plausible confounds – GDP per capita, government AI messaging, media environment – that likely correlate with both individualism and AI sentiment. The strength of the relationship ($R^2 = 0.72$) is unusually high for cross-national attitude research, which

is itself a reason for appropriate caution rather than overclaiming a fully isolated cultural effect. Full detail in the accompanying report.